

THE GREAT AIRSHIP SCARE

By DENNIS STAMEY (Illustrated by Charles Roller, Jr.)

In the quiet evening of November 18, 1896, hundreds of residents in Sacramento, Calif., gazed skyward at a metallic, cylindrical craft drifting through the heavens. The object cast down brilliant beams of light upon the city, and then slowly headed out on its predestined course to San Francisco.

The following evening, the bay communities of Oakland and San Francisco were plunged into panic when another flying vessel made a low level descent above the streets. Horses bolted, buggies overturned, and pedestrians ran in terror. The strange airship maintained a straight-line flight out toward the coastline, and then disappeared.

"My entire family saw the machine when it came across the bay from Oakland," commented then Mayor Suro of San Francisco.

Frightened, bewildered, the newspapers and the people of Northern California were desperately trying to make some sense out of the mystery. Descriptions generally agreed that the flying monster was about 150 feet in length, equipped with powerful searchlights and four rotor-like arms. It seemed to be, at best, rather cumbersome and exhibited no spectacular outburst of speed. Yet the craft could easily outperform anything man could put up into the air, at that date.

A streetcar driver, Shelby Yost, and his eleven passengers told newsmen at Oakland that an illuminated object had passed over the downtown section on the evening of November 22. It sped silently across the horizon and then cast an intense, blinding glow over the entire community.

"I didn't want to admit I'd gone crazy," said Yost, "but for a minute, I thought my senses had deserted me."

The December 2, 1896, edition of the *Los Angeles Times* broke the strange story of electrician John A. Horen from San Jose, Calif., probably the first man ever to step inside one of these marvelous airships. It made headlines across the nation, and here

is some brief text from his account:

"We left California in the morning and headed westward. The ship travelled by means of two propellers...movement was noiseless and swift. The motive power was not steam or electricity. It was a wonderful machine and can be stopped and made to stand still anywhere in the air..."

Horen said the pilot was 45 years of age and completely human. The airship reportedly took him on a quick excursion to Honolulu which he described as brilliantly lighted with lamps.

The article in the *Times* concluded, "He sticks to his story and bears the name of a hard-working man."

About the same time, William Bull Meek of Comptonville, Calif., and his four companions encountered a normal looking fellow whose airship had just landed in a desolate valley. Meek, who was interviewed by reporters from *The Sacramento Bee*, said that the "man stepped from the ship and said he had come from the Montezuma Mountains...wherever they are."

By December the airships left the scene as mysteriously as they arrived. The sightings had been concentrated in a small area; but by March the following year, the aerial performers returned to becloud the skies throughout the country. It seemed as if a well-planned invasion was beginning.

Watchers in Omaha on the night of March 29 reported some sort of controlled aerial vehicle roaming the evening sky. The object, conceivably the same one, was again seen the next night over Denver, where witnesses described it as brightly illuminated, cruising at high altitude and moving northwest.

On April 1, *The New York Sun* gave sporadic running accounts of a strange craft reported around Kansas City, Mo., which paused from time to time to send down beams of light. Various communities in Texas also reported sightings, including Dallas,

Fort Worth, Marshall and Beaumont.

The New York Herald of April 11 reported that on the nights of April 9 and 10, Chicago was flooded with stories of eerie lights that were seen from 8 p.m. until 2 o'clock in the morning. "Thousands of persons declared the lights seen in the northwest were those of an airship..." said the *Herald*. Some declared that they could distinguish two cigar-shaped objects and great wings."

Adolph Winkle and John Hylle swore a craft landed in a field two miles north of Springfield, Ill., on April 15. Aboard the machine were two men and a woman. The farmhands excitedly blurted out their story: "They said the ship came from Quincy, flying 90 miles in thirty minutes. They plan on making a report to the government when Cuba is declared free."

Several people in Benton, Texas, watched a cigar-shaped vessel on the night of April 16 as it crossed between them and the moon.

A story from the *Daily Post* at Childress, Texas, reported the observation of a fast-moving aerial body about two thousand feet high and on a westerly course, on April 17.

That same date yielded a number of tantalizing incidents including the alleged crash of a spaceship near the tiny village of Aurora, Texas. A correspondent for the *Dallas Morning News*, S.E. Haydon, visited the crash-site and reported that the remains of the ship and its eerie looking pilot were being collected. The spaceman was also going to be buried, he said, with full ceremony in tribute to a brave voyager.

But just as bizarre is the chilling incident telegraphed from Williamston, Mich., and picked up in an edition of *The Lansing State Republican*:

"Williamston, Mich., April 17—This morning at a mile south and a half mile west of this village, a balloon or flying machine landed in a field. A dozen farmers watched the airship for

an hour before it landed. When it landed, they gathered around and suffered from the heat.

"A strange man, if man he might be called, was in charge of the ship. He had plenty of clothes but seemed to have no use for them. He was almost naked and suffered from the heat.

"He is judged to be 10 feet tall and his talk, while musical, seems to be a kind of bellowing. One of the braver farmers approached the bellowing being and got a kick that will last him for some time, as his hip was broken.

"Great excitement prevails here. Lots of people are flocking here from Okemos and Locke to view the strange being from a safe distance. No one cares to go near. He seems to be trying to talk to everyone. The people...who have not seen him refuse to believe, although six of the best people swear it is the truth. At 8:10 last evening the ship passed over the village and many people watched its flight. The being returned to the vessel and flew away."

At Sisterville, W. Va., a quiet little town on the Ohio river, a luminous red object sailed in from the northwest at about 9 p.m. on April 19. It flashed brilliant searchlights and immediately began throwing the village in havoc. The sawmill whistle was blowing frantically as hundreds clogged into the streets to glimpse at the fantastic aerial visitor. The craft was like an immense cigar with two protruding fins on either side. Observers estimated it to have been about 180 feet in length and about 50 feet in diameter. All of the witnesses were able to make out flashing red, white and green lights along the side and at the stern.

That same night in Atlanta, Texas, a farmer named Jim Nelson had his hair "stand out with fright" when an airship slowly descended and momentarily hovered above him.

But perhaps the most amazing account is the startling experience of Captain Jim Hooten, a well-known Iron Mountain railroad conductor whose story appeared in the April 22, 1897, issue of *The Arkansas Gazette*, Little Rock. Capt. Hooten had been out hunting near Homan when it became dark: "I started to make my way back to the railroad station. As I was tramping through the brush my

attention was attracted by a familiar sound, like the noise of a locomotive airpump."

Suddenly he came upon five men repairing an odd-looking machine. "There was a medium-sized man who wore smoked glasses," said Hooten. "I mentioned the noise sounded like a Westinghouse air brake. 'Perhaps it does my friend,' he replied. 'We are using condensed air...but you will know more later on.'"

Capt. Hooten said the front of the ship ended in an abrupt knife-like edge. He recalled, "The sides of the craft bulged gradually, then receded. There were three large wheels upon each side...arranged so that they became concave as they moved forward...The man said good-bye, the ship rose with a hissing sound...in less than the twinkle of an eye the ship disappeared from sight."

The April 23rd issue of *The Modern News*, Harrisburg, Ark., carried the report of an ex-Senator Harris who also encountered some airship pilots when the vessel landed near his home. The crew consisted of an old, bearded man, a woman, and two young men. Harris was told by his informants that someone long ago had learned how to overcome gravity. The elderly man said he was able to secure the plans and experimented with the airship. They were scheduled to visit the planet Mars before putting the ship on public tour.

Harris declined to take a ride aboard the craft, and seconds later it rose swiftly into the sky.

Daniel Gray, a farmer living near Flint, Mich., was working in his field on April 23 when he heard "a terrible rumbling and whizzing sound directly over his head." Gazing upward, Gray was astonished to see a dark object traversing the sky at a high rate of speed. He was puzzled and rather dazed, but suddenly noticed a newspaper dropping from out of the sky. Upon examining it, he saw the newspaper came from Toronto, Canada, dated Oct. 5, 1896. The paper was dry and very well preserved.

The Daily Texarkanian, Texarkana, Ark., published on the same date as the above happenings, gave the account of Judge Lawrence A. Bryne's face-to-face encounter with oriental-like beings aboard an object

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which was anchored near the McKinney Bayou. The three men spoke in a strange language and had distinctive features like that of someone from the Far East. They motioned for Bryne to join them, to his astonishment.

The machinery was made of aluminum and the gas to raise and lower the ship was pumped into an aluminum tank," recalled Bryne.

The Houston Daily Post of April 28, contained a most interesting account:

"Merkel, Texas, April 26—Some parties returning from church last night noticed a heavy object dragging along with a rope attached. They followed it until in crossing the railroad it caught on a rail. On looking up, they saw what they supposed was the airship. It was not near enough to get an idea of the dimensions. A light could be seen protruding from several windows, and there was a bright light in front like a headlight of a locomotive. After some 10 minutes, a man was seen descending the rope. He came near enough to be plainly seen. He wore a light blue sailor suit, and was small in size. He stopped when he discovered the parties at the anchor, and cut the rope below him and sailed off in a northeast direction. The anchor is now on exhibition at the blacksmith shop of Elliott and Miller, and is attracting the attention of hundreds of people."

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We must also recall the testimonies of Deputy Sheriff John McLemore and Constable John J. Sumpter of Hot Springs, Arkansas who met the occupants of a flying ship on May 13, 1897. An affidavit followed and here is some of that statement:

"While riding northwest from Hot Springs on the night of May 6, 1897, we noticed a bright light high in the heavens. About a hundred yards ahead we saw two persons moving around with lights. Drawing our Winchester, we demanded: 'Who is that, and what are you doing here?'"

"A man with a dark beard stepped forward and said he and the young woman were traveling through the country in an airship. We could see the outlines of the ship, which was around sixty feet long and cigar-shaped. It was dark and raining and a young man was filling a big sack with water. The woman was careful to keep back in the dark."

The two laymen were offered a free ride in order to get out of the rain, but they declined. The bearded man said he was going to Nashville, Tenn., after seeing the country. Unfortunately, the witnesses left before the ship ascended into the air since they were hurrying to get home.

The airships finally vanished after May, although there were a few reported sightings in 1898 and some activity continuing into 1905. Were they new-fangled contraptions built by some ingenious party of inventors? It seems unlikely. Did the pilots want us to believe this in order to conceal their real identity and purpose? The angry, bellowing giant in Williamston, Mich.; the strange, oriental men near the McKinney Bayou in Arkansas; and the "little man" seen in Merkel, Texas, all seem to tally with modern-day reports of UFO occupants.

These reports were well documented; they are representative of a large amount of datum, and were published in both the lay and scientific presses.

Through a close scrutiny of the sightings in this period, perhaps we can arrive at some conclusive answers which still awaits us in the mystery of the UFO.

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